

TRIATHLON 2026

COOKING CATEGORY — STUDY GUIDE

Welcome to the Cooking Category of Triathlon 2026! This year's challenges are designed to test creativity, culinary knowledge, teamwork, adaptability, time management, presentation, and execution.

Contestants should be prepared to think on their feet and make thoughtful decisions within the constraints of each round.

Round	Challenge	Duration	Elimination
1	Sandwich it up	30-40 Minutes	Active
2	Relay Race	60-75 Minutes	Active
3	A Story on a Plate	90-120 Minutes	Active

Round 1: Sandwich It Up

ROUND DURATION: 30–40 MINUTES

ELIMINATION: ACTIVE IN THIS ROUND

Teams will be provided with brown bread and a selection of contents/fillings. Using the ingredients available, teams must create sandwiches that are both appealing and enjoyable to eat.

THE MAIN CHALLENGE: WEIGHT LIMIT — 160 G

The set weight limit for the completed sandwich is 160 g. Staying within the weight portion is the fundamental requirement of the round. Teams must carefully select, portion, and assemble their ingredients while ensuring that their final sandwich remains within the specified weight limit.

Round 2: Relay Race

ROUND DURATION: 60–75 MINUTES

ELIMINATION: ACTIVE IN THIS ROUND

Teams will be divided into two halves. They will work together on chicken enchiladas. All teams will be provided with the same ingredients and will work towards preparing the assigned dish through a relay-style handover.

- First half: The first half of the team will begin preparation and may work for 20 minutes.
- Handover: After 20 minutes, the first half must stop and the second half will take over the preparation.
- Continuation: The second half must continue from the point at which the first half stopped and complete the dish.
- Communication restriction: Members who are waiting may not communicate with the members currently cooking.
- Teams should plan carefully, maintain an organized workstation, and make their progress understandable for the next half of the team.

Round 3: A Story on a Plate

ROUND DURATION: 90–120 MINUTES

ELIMINATION: ACTIVE IN THIS ROUND

The final challenge invites contestants to tell their story through a sweet dish of their own creation.

Contestants will not be given a specific dessert to prepare. Instead, they will receive a selection of ingredients and a fixed amount of time, and must decide for themselves what dessert to create.

The dessert should carry a personal significance for the contestant. It may be inspired by a cherished memory, a person, a place, a tradition, an experience, or another moment that holds meaning.

Contestants must be prepared to explain the story behind their dish, why it is important to them, and what significance it holds.

The choice of dessert is itself part of the challenge. Contestants must consider the ingredients provided, the techniques required, and the time available before committing to their concept. They must create and complete a sweet dish that is achievable within the given time limit.

Preparation requirement: Contestants are expected to have prior know-how of the dish they intend to make. They must enter the challenge with sufficient knowledge of the recipe, techniques, and general preparation process, as phones and other devices will not be permitted during the round.

MasterChef-style element: Contestants will have a limited time period to select and plan around the ingredients available before beginning the main preparation.

General Guidelines

- All ingredients will be provided to the delegates; delegates are not required to bring ingredients unless specifically instructed by the category head. Any extra item brought in beyond the instructions of the heads will have to be taken permission for before the round begins.
- **Phones and other electronic devices will NOT be allowed during the competition.**
- Contestants must have prior know-how of any dish they intend to prepare and should be familiar with the relevant recipe and techniques before entering the challenge.
- All delegates **MUST** wear proper headgear/cap and an apron throughout the rounds. Delegates should bring their own headgear/cap and apron.
- All teams **MUST** keep their counters, equipment, and surroundings clean and organized.
- All teams **MUST** adhere to the rules and maintain proper decorum throughout the competition.
- Delegates must behave professionally and respectfully toward judges, organizers, volunteers, and other competitors.
- Unnecessary wastage of ingredients is strictly not allowed and will be kept in mind when scoring.
- Delegates should manage their time carefully and ensure that their final dishes are ready for judging within the allotted time.
- Staple condiments (ketchup, mayonnaise, mustard) will be provided by the category heads. Any special or specific kind of sauce brought in by the delegates must be approved by the category head before the round starts. This rule applies to any other item as well.
- Delegates are **required** to bring their cooking oil with them on all days. Any kind of oil used for frying, cooking, oiling, kneading etc will **NOT** be provided by the category heads.
- Delegates are **required** to bring their own beaters for Round 2 and Round 3.
- Delegates are **required** to **bring their own** serving AND takeaway dishes/containers as the host school or category heads will not be responsible for that.
- Arguments, abusive language, cheating, deliberate disruption, or interference with another team's work may result in disqualification.
- ALL DELEGATES **MUST** REPORT TO THE CATEGORY HEADS **30 MINUTES** BEFORE IN ORDER TO REGISTER DOWN THEIR TEAM NAMES AND SLOTS.

Judging Criteria:

All rounds will consist of 100 points with subject to category division of points. Category heads hold authority to make any on spot changes.

Round 1:

Teams scoring below 88/100 will be eliminated.

- **Appearance 15pts** : This criteria will focus solely on how appealing your dish looks on its own.
- **Presentation 10pts** : will account for the servingware, the elements of decor/garnish, and the method of presentation delegates chose.
- **Taste 10pts** : is a fundamental criteria of the cooking category. There needs to be a sync of flavours used in the dish. You can not simply put mint leaves on brown bread and expect it to taste good.
- **Execution 10pts** : will factor in the effectiveness of techniques, personal and surrounding hygiene, cleanliness of cooking stations, and team harmony.
- **Use of Ingredients 10pts** : will be a vital criteria as there would be a set group of ingredients and delegates will have to choose from them. It will look over the amount and combination of ingredients the delegates used.
- **Weight Limit 25pts** : This is the key criteria for Round 1's judging.
- **Time management 20pts** : is a fundamental criteria and will be factored in when counting points.

Round 2: Enchiladas

Teams scoring below 91/100 will be eliminated.

- **Appearance 15pts** : This criteria will focus solely on how appealing your dish looks on its own.
- **Presentation 10pts** : will account for the servingware, the elements of decor/garnish, and the method of presentation delegates chose.
- **Taste 25pts** : is a fundamental criteria of the cooking category. There needs to be a sync of flavours used in the dish. We are not here to eat tortillas wrapped around bland chicken.
- **Execution 10pts** : will factor in the effectiveness of techniques, personal and surrounding hygiene, cleanliness of cooking stations, and team harmony.
- **Use of Ingredients 10pts** : will factor in their use of provided measured ingredients. Demand of excessive extra ingredients will result in deduction of points.
- **Time management 30pts** : is a fundamental criteria and will be factored in when counting points.

Round 3: Dessert (subject to choice)

Teams scoring below 97 will be eliminated. If a situation opposed to the criteria rises then mediation will take place.

- **Appearance 15pts** : This criteria will focus solely on how appealing your dish looks on its own.
- **Presentation 10pts** : will account for the servingware, the elements of decor/garnish, and the method of presentation delegates chose.
- **Taste 15pts** : is a fundamental criteria of the cooking category. There needs to be a sync of flavours used in the dish. It takes one bite to taste unnecessary baking powder in your mouth.

- **Execution 10pts** : will factor in the effectiveness of techniques, personal and surrounding hygiene, cleanliness of cooking stations, and team harmony.
- **Creativity 10pts** : will account for the choice of dessert and whether or not it's a common choice amongst other teams.
- **Storytelling 15pts** : There should be a clear idea or inspiration behind the dessert which links to a connection between the team and the dessert.
- **Use of Ingredients 15pts** : will factor in their use of provided measured ingredients. Demand of excessive extra ingredients will result in deduction of points.
- **Time management 20pts**: is a fundamental criteria and will be factored in when counting points.

Note:

The proceedings, timings, ingredients, equipment, and requirements of each round may be altered at the sole discretion of the Category Head.

EVERYTHING MENTIONED ABOVE IS TO BE INCLUDED IN THE OFFICIAL STUDY GUIDE FOR THE COOKING CATEGORY.